

The rear in this test was brought up by—apart from the Jazz mini home theatre—the Mercury HT 5800, which came very close to the performance of Artis S7100—the slim, elegant and expensive-looking speakers. “Never judge a book by its cover” never sounded truer!



Artis X10 (5.1)

In our audio CD tests, however, the Artis X10 fought back—and with gusto! It comfortably beat all the other speakers or tied with them for the first spot, except for in the Hindi Instrumental Audio CD test, where, surprisingly, it lost out in a big way to the Hyundai, Altec Lansing BS3151R and Creative Inspire 5200. As a matter of fact, it came in fourth, after the second-placed Creative MegaWorks and Soomoku 5.1 systems.

We then came to our DVD movie test. This was the first test where we were going to hear the sound in real 5.1 surround, so we fell over each other to get the best seats!

Here, the Artis X10 was not alone at the top spot; the Creative Inspire 5200 tied with it and marginally beat the Creative 5.1 MegaWorks. The Philips A3.610 was slightly disappointing in this test. We found significant distortion at even mid-volume levels.

We were really taken aback by the sheer clarity of sound reproduction done by the X10. In the clip, there is a scene where a guy puts his helmet on the car-boot, while the car is motion and is surrounded by four other cars and a truck.

In all the other speakers, the thud of the helmet was mostly lost in the chaos

of sound all around, but not in the X10: it was faithfully and distinctly reproduced, without compromising on the bass punch we were getting from the revving truck engine. Really great stuff!

The Typhoon 5.1 Amplified System Pro was outstanding in this particular test, and stood a proud third. Soomoku did quite well and stood fourth, but started to sound a bit too harsh in the scene where the car glass shatters.

The sound of broken glass falling on the ground wasn't reproduced with much clarity, either. The speaker that really lost in this round was the Creative PC Works LX520. There was so much distortion in this system that the only aspect of the scene it demonstrated was confusion and chaos!

The Altec Lansing BS 3151R's performance was just about average when compared to the other speakers. The slim Artis S7100 performed terribly. There was a huge amount of distortion, even at a volume level of less than half!

We now come to the last and final performance test—the *Half-Life 2* demo run.

The minute the demo starts, there is some music, and that in itself is a pretty good indicator of how good or bad the speaker will perform here. The minute we plugged in the Creative MegaWorks, we knew we were in for a treat.

The thump of the sound made everyone around sit up and take notice. The

speakers gave an excellent performance, and reproduced even the faintest sound in detail. The bomb explosions and the gunshots, the sound of the gun reloading... it was all so realistic, and it was all we could do to not look around us!

There was, however, a strange distorted sound during a specific part of the demo—it was very faint but noticeably there. Turning up the volume made it really clear, and that's where it lost out on in this test.

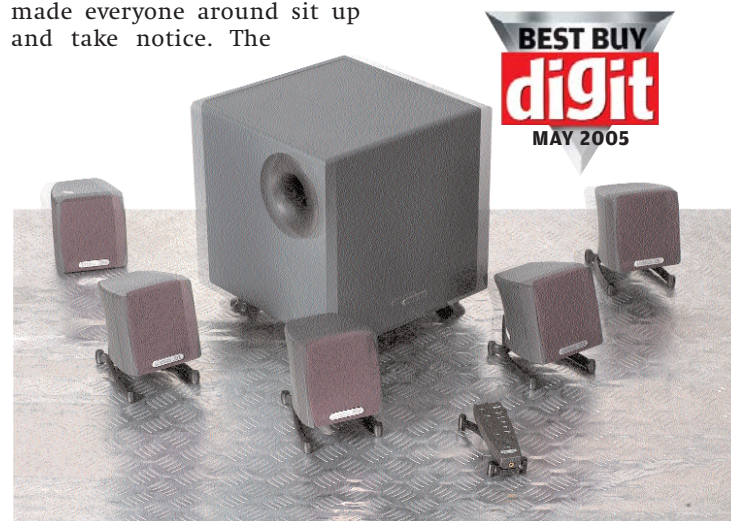
Once we unplugged the MegaWorks, we knew it for sure that we would not be getting a better performer in this test. We were wrong.

The minute we plugged in the Artis X10, the controlled bass and excellent treble reproduction indicated that we had to eat our words, and boy, did we feel happy about it!

We fired up the demo, and the sound was in every way comparable to the MegaWorks. What we were looking for was if it would get distorted at higher volumes, as was the case with the Creative MegaWorks.

The demo began, and we were highly impressed with the clarity of this system. The resemblance to the Bose was not just limited to design! This baby could perform and beat the best systems out there!

We turned the volume all the way up, and unfortunately were greeted with disappointing distortion. However, the distortion began at a marginally higher level than the Creative one, and hence it edged



Creative 5.1 Megaworks 550 THX (5.1)